



Stories, Formulate a story using the visuals and dashboards Transcript

Hello everyone, welcome to BITS Pilani Digital. We will be continuing our learning journey for the course Data Visualisation and Storytelling. We will be now taking you to the module Building Dashboards and Visual Storytelling topic.

Today we will be discussing the topic why storytelling matters. Storytelling has been a potent source of conveying information for humans. For human communication, stories are the central piece.

Over the years, we have communicated across generations using stories. Furthermore, humans retain much more information when the information is conveyed in the form of a story than in the form of raw data. Simply seeing a graphic and building a narrative around a graphic would give you more conviction and therefore retention and belief.

We will now understand why storytelling matters. Human communication is centred on stories. From ages memorial, we have communicated through stories carrying across generations of knowledge and experience.

Today's world is no different. Humans retain most form of the information if that is conveyed in a narrative than in the form of a raw data. Therefore, building narratives whenever you are conveying information will increase the chance of retention and action by the audience that you are targeting.

Storytelling helps leaders to persuade, build teams, and get attention of the audience. People remember the details of their favourite movie than the annual report of their company in which they are holding the shares. So, this should motivate that stories are a potent source for conveying information.

In this course, once we have learned the data visualisation part, the necessary raw material and toolkits, we will now move to the stage where we will use them to tell stories. And before that, we will try to understand why stories and how to tell a story. So, the science of storytelling, the cognitive value, whenever you hear a story, it is not just the language centres of the brain that get activated.

There are other centres of the brain that get activated with emotion, thinking, so on. Story helps recall, especially a better structured story helps you recall and retain more information. When facts are wrapped in narrative, they are 22 times more potent and more likely to be remembered.

Finally, so when a compelling story is told, you are more certainly to get emotionally attached and remember it practically. Now, let us take an example and understand the impact of storytelling. Look at the visual that is on the left of your slide.

This is the 2000 presidential election and popular vote in US. This is the first time Democrats have been represented with blue. The states which are won by the Democrats have been represented in blue and the ones which have been won by the Republicans have been represented in red.

Since then, by default, the political communication has associated blue with the Democrats and red with Republicans. You can see on to the graph on to your right, though it is not a choropleth map or a representation of geographical data, it is a simple bar chart. The choice of colours still remain blue and red with Biden and Trump and even Kamala Harris and Trump.

So, these things tell one this underline a very important factor. Once a narrative is built into our human perception, it is very difficult for us to change it and most of the times once if the narrative is right, it is likely to continue for a long period and the entire perception and the story narrative building would happen around it. So, visuals and the story that follows are a potent source to create certain communication paradigms.

Now, we will talk about how to present a story or how to do a presentation in general. So, I do not mean presentation by, I do not restrict myself to a PowerPoint presentation. I will talk about presentation in general.

So, we talk about GER Reynolds principles. Whenever you are presenting, there has to be restraint and you have to limit the unnecessary elements. You have to eliminate the unnecessary elements and limit your attention only to the most necessary elements conveying the information that you want to and if you are talking about a PPT, leverage the white space on the slide strategically to drive impact.

We have seen this in the visual storytelling part in the earlier lessons how to use these pre-attentive attributes of colour space where white space is an important strategic element. Finally, you should have naturalness in your delivery with confidence and connect with the audience. So, storytelling is also an emotive exercise in which you have to invest and train for delivering the message naturally.

There are Heath Brothers success principles of making a presentation. They state that an idea can be conveyed or idea can stick with the audience when it is successfully communicated. What are the attributes of the success? It should be simple.

The idea that you are trying to explain should be simple, should be unexpected for the audience and it should be concrete idea, it should be credible, it should be conveyed in an emotional tone and finally it should be storied. Such a presenting style would be engaging, focused and memorable to the audience and most likely to clarify the information or the message that you want to showcase in your visual. We have again I am reiterating till now we have been discussing how to build effective visuals.

Now, we are talking about with these effective visuals how are you going to convey it more effectively to your audience. You have to build or wrap it up in a narrative and a good storytelling framework will help you with that. Now, we are coming to another principle we are now coming to another Japanese principle called Pecha Kucha.

Pecha Kucha is nothing but art of visual brevity. Brevity is nothing but simplicity. This talks about the presentation style where you focus on the content and less on the talking.

The challenge is to present 20 slides, each slide taking 20 seconds that is roughly about 6 minutes 40 seconds you try to convey your entire message. The restriction on time makes you talk less and focus more on your past visualisation to convey the information that you wanted to get it across. You should not be narrating the content that is there on the slides much beyond the point.

They should be self-explanatory and they should connect with the audience so that the flow is there in the limited time and the message gets across. By practising such a principle you will focus more on the most essential topics or the aspects that you want to convey to the audience and fine-tune your visuals to the extent that they naturally flow to the audience without much intervention or requiring you to talk and you can complete your presentation in the stipulated time. The focus is on emphasising story plus visuals and there should be no data overload.

I would like to add you should remember simplicity is the ultimate sophistication. So while simple visuals when crafted clearly can deliver more information than overloaded cluttered visuals. This principle is used across businesses, business schools and conferences globally where the time limit is there for presenting ideas.

Then we will now look at what happens when you tell a boring story or use the visualisations or presentations in the wrong format. So what we what is famously or notoriously called as death by presentation where long boring presentations are made with heavy text content, no proper order or visual connect with the audience. You feel really bored to sit with sit through such presentations and the information or the knowledge transfer is virtually close to zero.

Through half through the time you would lose interest and not pay attention to what is being told. Resultantly if a key business decision or a policy decision has to be made during such presentations it is most certainly will be made on concocted assumptions or simple shortcuts at times leading to bad results. One such case was the NASA disaster of Columbia shuttle.

The presentation which was given on safety features was not well prepared, it was cluttered, it does not it did not convey or highlight the significant actual risk which could



have made the decisions more appropriate to avert the disaster. For example look at the presentation that was shown and it you can see it does not have any visual hierarchy which we have seen in the last couple of classes where you can order the slide using text, space, size, colour to bring the attention of the viewer to a particular topic which is the most important line. So in fact sadly the most important line has been highlighted in the smallest font at the bottom most likely losing the attention of the audience therefore not figuring a part of the decisions.

Resultantly there was a disaster which could have been averted. Small things like this can have real world consequences depending upon to which forum you are presenting. However having said this there is always scope to improve your presentations and make them lively and building a narrative around them.

Finally how to fix death by powerpoint. So you should first understand what is the main message that you want to get across and try to create a visual hype and importantly if there is any visuals and alternative visualisations that you can convey by converting text data you should use them and that will make the presentations more lively. We are pausing for at this yeah thank you.

-----End-----